

MANFREDONIA, SIPONTO AND THE SALT FLATS OF MARGHERITA DI SAVOIA

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CAP. 1 — INTRO: THE SIX O'CLOCK SHIFT

The six o'clock shift is the best.

In summer the sun rises over the sea, behind the basins, and the water turns pink. It's not an optical illusion. It's the light filtering through dissolved salt, through the microclimate of the salt flats, through the millions of microorganisms that colour the most concentrated basins.

My name is Antonello. Fifty-four years old. I'm from Manfredonia — born there, live there, always go back there. But I work here, at Margherita di Savoia, at the salt flats. Thirty years.

My job is called salt quality control. I measure water density, sodium chloride concentration, the purity of the final product. Every day. Every season. Since I was twenty-four.

I've seen these basins at every possible hour. In the pink dawn of July, in the December fog, in the orange sunset when the flamingos all rise together and the sky fills with wings.

If you want to understand this stretch of Puglia — the salt, the gulf, the ancient cities behind you — come with me.

CAP. 2 — THE SALT FLATS: HOW SALT WORKS

The Margherita di Savoia salt flats are the largest in Italy.

Four thousand hectares of basins, channels, embankments. A hydraulic system built over centuries, refined, never fully automated — because salt is not just another industrial product. Salt is alive.

The process is simple in theory. Seawater enters the evaporation basins — the first ones, called mother waters. Sun and wind evaporate the water. Salt concentration increases. The water moves from one basin to the next, getting denser, getting more coloured.

When the concentration is right — and I'm the one who says so, with my instruments and thirty years of trained eye — the water enters the crystallisation basins. There the salt settles to the bottom. A white layer forms, compact, crystalline.

Harvesting happens in summer, between July and September. Machines scraping the bottom, mountains of white salt piling up along the banks. From a distance they look like snow. In August, with forty degrees of heat, it feels like a joke nature is playing.

CAP. 3 — THE PINK FLAMINGOS

The flamingos are here almost all year.

Since 1992 they've settled in permanently. In summer they're most numerous — from June to September the basins fill with pink. But I see them in winter too, in smaller groups, in the central basins. Since 1997 they've been breeding here. They've become the symbol of Margherita.

The greater flamingo — *Phoenicopterus roseus* — is not a tropical bird. It lives in the Mediterranean. It breeds in Sardinia, in the Camargue in France, in Spain. And here it found a place to stay.

Their pink colour comes from what they eat — microscopic algae and crustaceans rich in carotenoids. In the salt flat basins there's plenty of all that. A flamingo that doesn't eat these foods loses its colour. It turns white.

Early in the morning, when I arrive at work, sometimes I stop for five minutes on the roadside. I watch them. Thirty years and I never get tired. There's something impossible about a flamingo at dawn. It shouldn't exist, and yet there it is.

CAP. 4 — MARGHERITA DI SAVOIA: THE CITY OF SALT

Margherita di Savoia is a city built on salt.

That's not a metaphor. The town was born as a settlement for salt workers — the salinari. The oldest neighbourhoods, the low houses near the embankment, the warehouses: everything exists because of salt.

Salt from Margherita had enormous value for centuries. Before industrial food preservation, salt was the only way to preserve fish, meat, vegetables. Whoever controlled salt controlled food. Whoever controlled food controlled everything.

Even today, the thermal baths of Margherita di Savoia are famous. The mother waters of the salt flats — those high-concentration basins I use for my quality checks — are used for therapeutic treatments. Dermatitis, psoriasis, joint pain. People come from all over Italy.

CAP. 5 — THE GULF OF MANFREDONIA

When I look north from these basins, I see the Gargano.

The promontory rises from the water like a sleeping animal. The shape is unmistakable — the dark mass of the forest, the white cliffs facing the sea, the high silhouette of Monte Sant'Angelo.

The Gulf of Manfredonia is a wide gulf, open to the east onto the Adriatic. To the north the Gargano closes it like a wall. To the south the coast opens towards Barletta, towards Bari, towards the rest of Puglia.

This gulf has always been a thoroughfare. Ships coming from the East passed through here. Pilgrims heading to Monte Sant'Angelo landed here. The Saracens came to raid here. And Manfredi of Swabia, eight hundred years ago, decided this was the place for a city.

CAP. 6 — MANFREDONIA: THE FOUNDER'S CITY

Manfredonia is a young city, by Puglia's standards.

It was founded in 1256 by Manfredi of Swabia — son of Emperor Frederick II, King of Sicily, one of the most powerful men of his time. Manfredi chose this point on the gulf because it was sheltered, because the harbour was natural, because from here he could control the Adriatic routes.

Before Manfredonia there was Siponto. But Siponto was disappearing — earthquakes, malaria, a silted-up harbour. Manfredi moved Siponto's inhabitants to the new city that bore his name. A city built from scratch, by design, with straight streets and a castle at the centre.

I was born there. And every time I walk through the historic centre, I still see the original layout — the medieval street axes, the alleys that slope down to the harbour, the castle looking out to sea. A city that was planned, not grown by chance.

CAP. 7 — THE SWABIAN-ANGEVIN CASTLE

The castle of Manfredonia is one of the finest in Puglia.

Built by Manfredi in the thirteenth century, expanded by the Angevins in the fourteenth, modified by the Aragonese and then the Spanish. Every ruler left their mark — a taller tower, a deeper moat, a different bastion.

Today the castle houses the National Museum of the Gargano. Worth visiting for the Daunian stelae alone — carved stone slabs left by a pre-Roman people who lived on the Gargano three thousand years ago. Human figures, animals, hunting scenes. A writing that isn't writing yet — images that tell stories.

From the walkway along the walls you can see the entire gulf. The Gargano to the north. The salt flats to the south. The sea ahead. Manfredi knew how to pick his spots.

CAP. 8 — SIPONTO: THE ABANDONED CITY

Two kilometres from Manfredonia, near the beach, is what remains of Siponto.

It's not much, at first glance. A square, a few columns, the basilica. But Siponto was one of the great cities of medieval Puglia — a trading port, a bishop's seat, the embarkation point for pilgrims heading to the shrine of Saint Michael at Monte Sant'Angelo.

Pilgrims from all over Europe landed here. French, German, English — all of them passed through Siponto before climbing to the Gargano. The city was full of inns, hospitals for the sick, churches.

Then came the earthquakes, in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries. The coastline subsided slightly — imperceptible to someone living a single lifetime, enormous across centuries. The marshes advanced. Malaria arrived. Siponto emptied slowly, like a cup with a crack in it.

CAP. 9 — THE BASILICA OF SANTA MARIA DI SIPONTO

The Basilica of Santa Maria di Siponto is still standing.

It is one of the most beautiful Romanesque churches in Puglia — perhaps in all of Italy. Built in the eleventh century, in white stone, with a gallery of blind arches running along the outer walls. Simple. Solid. Like the people who built it.

But the extraordinary thing is not the church above. It's what lies beneath.

Going down into the crypt you reach a paleo-Christian basilica — a church from the fifth or sixth century, built when Siponto was still a living and powerful city. The walls are ancient. The floor still has its original tiles, worn smooth by seventeen hundred years of

footsteps.

The Romanesque builders of the eleventh century did not demolish the older church. They built on top of it. They preserved it, the way you preserve something too sacred to touch.

When I go down into that crypt, I always think of my work at the salt flats. Salt preserves. Stone preserves. Certain things resist time better than we think.

CAP. 10 — SALT AND TIME

Salt has a quality that almost nothing else in the world has: it doesn't deteriorate.

Salt found in Egyptian tombs is still salt. The salt in the deepest mines is millions of years old and hasn't changed. It preserves, protects, stops time for everything it touches.

Thirty years of early morning shifts have given me plenty of time to think about these things. I walk along the basins with my instruments, measuring density and concentration, and I think.

I think that this coast — the gulf, the salt flats, Siponto buried beneath, Manfredonia founded on a dead city — is a place where time works differently. Not slower. More visible. The traces don't disappear. They settle, like salt on the bottom of the basins, layer by layer.

CAP. 11 — WHAT TO DO AND HOW TO GET THERE

For the salt flats: the Margherita di Savoia Nature Reserve organises guided visits.

There's a nature trail along the embankments — on foot or by bicycle — that lets you observe the flamingos up close. Peak season is June to September, when flamingos are present in large numbers. Bring binoculars. And shoes that can get dirty — the embankments aren't always dry.

For Manfredonia: the castle is open to the public and worth visiting for the Daunian stelae. The historic centre is small and walkable in an hour. The harbour has good fish restaurants — the gulf is still generous with its catch.

For Siponto: the basilica is a few minutes' drive from Manfredonia, heading south along the coast road. Don't miss the crypt. It's free. Take five minutes of silence down there. It's worth more than any explanation.

CAP. 12 — THE TRANSHUMANCE: THE TRATTURI OF THE GARGANO

Before the salt, before the flamingos, before all of it — there were the tratturi.

Not machines — tratturi.

The tratturi are ancient grassy roads walked for centuries by shepherds driving their flocks between the mountains of Abruzzo and the plains of the Tavoliere in Puglia. In autumn they came down towards the sea. In spring they went back up to the mountains. The transhumance — this seasonal movement of flocks — shaped this landscape for three thousand years.

The Royal Tratturo that passes through these areas is sixty metres wide — a grassy motorway. Today it's partly swallowed by cultivated fields, partly paved over. But the route is still there — if you know what to look for, you can see it.

Every time I cross the plain between Manfredonia and Foggia I think of the shepherds who made this journey on foot. With thousands of sheep. For weeks. The salt they carried with them was as precious as gold.

CAP. 13 — THE TURKS AND MANFREDONIA: A DIFFICULT HISTORY

Manfredonia has had quiet centuries and terrible centuries.

In the seventeenth century the Turks arrived.

An Ottoman fleet attacked the city — looted it, partly burned it, took people away as slaves. It was common practice throughout the Mediterranean in those centuries — the southern Italian coasts were frequent targets. But Manfredonia was hit hard.

The city recovered. It rebuilt. It carried on. But the memory of that violence remained — in the watchtowers along the coast, in the churches rebuilt afterwards, in family stories passed down without anyone realising.

When I stop at the port of Manfredonia and look out to sea, I think about how many times this shore has witnessed things it would rather not have seen. The gulf looks calm. But it has a long memory.

CAP. 14 — THE PORT OF MANFREDONIA: FISHING BOATS AND EARLY MORNINGS

The port of Manfredonia wakes up before I do.

When I arrive at the salt flats at six, the fishing boats are already out. They leave at night — at two, at three. They come back in the morning with what they've caught: clams, squid, red mullet, prawns. The gulf of Manfredonia is still generous.

The fish from this gulf has a quality you can taste. I can't explain it in chemical terms — I feel it in the flavour. The squid here have nothing in common with the ones that arrive frozen from who knows where. And the clams — I'd recognise the clams from this gulf anywhere.

When I'm not on shift, on Sundays, I stop by the port. I buy fish directly from the fishermen. I take it all home. I cook. My wife says I always keep it too simple — just oil and lemon. But fresh fish doesn't need anything else.

CAP. 15 — THE BEACH OF SIPONTO: ARCHAEOLOGY AND SEA

The beach at Siponto is long and open.

No luxury hotels on the seafront — a few beach clubs, plenty of free shoreline. In summer the locals come — people from Manfredonia, from Foggia, the odd passing tourist. It's not Vieste, not as crowded as the Gargano to the north.

From the beach you can see the basilica. It's a hundred metres from the waterline — between the car park and the pine wood. It's strange to swim in the sea with twelve hundred years of history a hundred metres away. But in Puglia you get used to that.

Under the sand of this beach, and in the surrounding pine forest, there are still traces of Siponto that no one has excavated yet. Every now and then something turns up — a mosaic fragment, a column, remnants of walls. The city is still there, buried, waiting.

CAP. 16 — SALT AND MEDICINE: THE THERMAL BATHS

The waters of the Margherita di Savoia salt flats are not only for making salt.

The mother waters — those very high-concentration basins, where the water is dense and heavy — are used for thermal treatments. The Margherita di Savoia thermal baths are open and accredited by the National Health Service. This isn't wellness tourism — it's medicine.

Dermatitis, psoriasis, eczema — the salt-iodine treatment is documented as effective. People come on medical prescription, not just as tourists. I sent my brother there — he had a chronic skin problem that nothing else would shift. After two courses of treatment he improved significantly. I don't know the exact chemistry. I know what I saw.

The same waters the flamingos work in heal people. This place is strange and wonderful.

CAP. 17 — THE GULF IN SUMMER: WHAT TO EAT

The gulf of Manfredonia is generous.

The squid from the gulf are famous throughout Puglia. Small, tender, fried or grilled whole. In Manfredonia you'll find restaurants serving them just off the boat — that's not a marketing promise, it's the reality of an active working port.

The clams from the gulf are another story. The sandy seabed favours venus clams — the ones you open in a pan with garlic, oil and white wine. Simple, quick, perfect.

I eat at the port on Sundays — trattorias with no big signs, tables outside and fish from that morning. No fixed menu. They tell you what's in. You choose from that. It's the best way.

CAP. 18 — THE WINTER SEA: THE GULF WHEN IT'S EMPTY

In summer the gulf of Manfredonia is full of boats.

In winter it's empty.

Fishing boats, the occasional cargo ship in the distance, nothing else. The sea turns grey-green, the waves long and regular. The Gargano in the background looks darker — the vegetation doesn't shine the way it does in summer. The sky is low.

I prefer the gulf in winter. Not because it's more beautiful — it's more beautiful in summer. But in winter it's mine. When I arrive at the salt flats at six, there's no one there. Me, the flamingos, the wind. Nothing else.

In those moments I understand why I never left. Not for lack of opportunity. For this. For the winter mornings on the empty gulf.

CAP. 19 — THE CHARACTER OF MANFREDONIA'S PEOPLE

The people of Manfredonia have a reputation.

Direct. Sometimes too much.

It's not rudeness — it's a way of being in the world. No ceremony, no beating around the bush. If they say yes, it's yes. If they say no, it's no. There's nothing to interpret.

I come from those people. My father worked at the port — fisherman, then factory worker. He wasn't a man of many words. But what he said was precise. There was no room for misunderstanding in his house.

When I work at the salt flats, and write my quality reports — numbers, measurements, data — I think it's the same character. Reality is what it is. Numbers don't lie. The salt is good or it isn't. No grey areas in my work. And in my city.

CAP. 20 — FINALE: ANTONELLO SAYS GOODBYE

At half past seven I finish my first round of checks. I stop at the edge of the crystallisation basin — the furthest one, where the salt has already formed and is waiting to be harvested.

The sun is up now. The flamingos are still in the central basins, several hundred of them. The water reflects the Gargano. Behind me, a few kilometres away, Siponto lies under the sand and Manfredonia is waking up.

Every morning the same and every morning different. That's the secret of salt: it's always the same, but every crystal is unique.

This gulf has other stories.

The villages perched inland, where a park ranger knows every path and every fire, the forgotten coast between Rodi and Peschici where the road climbs past unnamed panoramas, the monks of Siponto who prayed where pagans had prayed before them, the islands where a boatman used to take Lucio Dalla into the violet caves. Each one has someone who tells it. Someone who never left.

The Gargano doesn't end here.